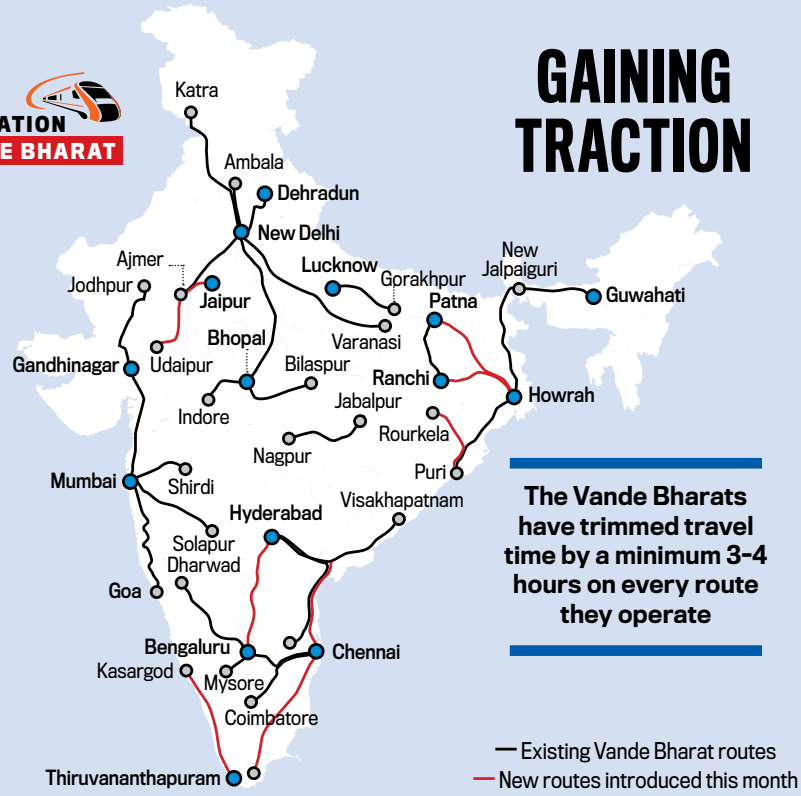
GAINING TRACTION



The Vande Bharats have trimmed travel time by a minimum 3-4 hours on every route they operate

OCCUPANCY

Average occupancy of the Vande Bharats in April to mid-Sept. 2023

LOWEST
25.8%
(Bhopal-Indore)

HIGHEST
177.21%
(Kasargod-Thiruvananthapuram)

34
routes
₹130 CR.
Average cost of a train

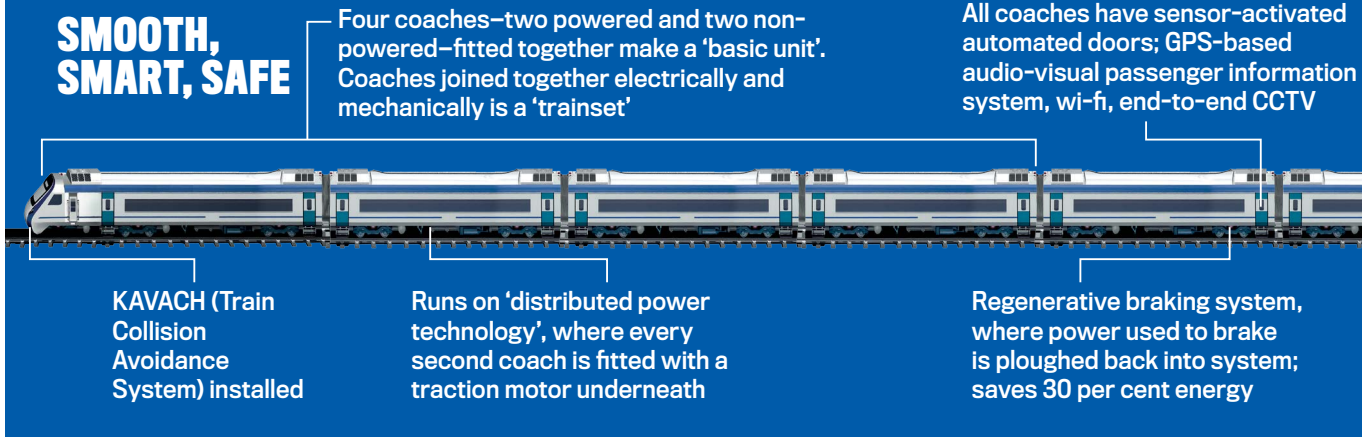
180
kmph
Top speed possible

0-160
kmph
in 140 secs

25
No. of improvements in the new Vande Bharat rakes

1,128
Passenger capacity in 16-coach train. Sleeper versions: **850**

SMOOTH, SMART, SAFE



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

Railways in this massive rolling-stock overhaul. Russia's rolling-stock major TMH will produce 120 trainsets of the sleeper variety in partnership with the Rail Vikas Nigam Limited. Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited, in partnership with Titagarh Rail Systems, will be producing 80. French mobility giant Alstom is in the final stages to bag an order for 100 Vande Bharats with aluminium bodies, as opposed to steel. At around Rs 140 crore per train, some Rs 10 crore more than the usual ones, the aluminium rakes will be lighter, requiring less maintenance and energy to run. "The money recoverable from end-of-life coaches, even in scrap, is much more thanks to aluminium; steel coaches don't offer that advantage," says a rail ministry official.

The railway equipment manufacturing industry in India is upbeat about the capital infusion in the market. "This kind of push is a game-changer for the Indian rail systems industry," says Tilak Raj Seth, vice-chairman of the rail transportation and equipment division, Confederation of Indian Industry (CII). "Quite like how the Maruti car in the mid-'80s created a demand for new, better car varieties, the train user will now fuel the demand of Vande Bharat trains...200 kmph semi-high-speed version and so on, boosting tremendous industrial activity in this field," says Seth.

The government clearly has a political investment in the new trains too. PM Modi has inaugurated all the trains so far, except the one on the Delhi-Katra route, targeting the Vaishno Devi pilgrims, which Union home minister Amit Shah flagged off. By the time the 2024 general election rolls in, the Vande Bharats should fit snugly into the BJP's overall development narrative. "The day is not far when Vande Bharat will connect every part of the country," PM Modi said, while flagging off the latest lot of nine trains. There is much to be learnt from that unifying spirit. ■